When a Difficulty Becomes a Disaster

What is the difficulty — and what am I predicting it means?

READING

Seneca, *Letters* 13.4–12; **Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 4**. Seneca examines anticipated troubles and the evidence for them. Epictetus prepares for familiar obstacles while preserving sound choice. Preparation acknowledges a possibility; it does not establish that the feared event will happen.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Invite an ordinary worry about a task or conversation. Personal crises need not become discussion examples.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	Discuss · 40	Close · 10
Welcome; passing is fine	Selected passages aloud	A difficult presentation: facts vs. predictions	The questions below	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Before a difficult presentation, which problems are known and which are predictions?
2. How do discomfort, uncertainty, or embarrassment affect the confidence you give a judgment?
3. What evidence would support the feared conclusion — and what would weaken it?
4. How does rehearsing one realistic obstacle differ from repeatedly imagining disaster?
5. If the difficulty is real, what remains yours to judge without minimizing the risk?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Name the difficulty precisely. In one pressured situation, state the present facts, name the prediction or evaluation added, and decide what the evidence supports. You may also rehearse one likely obstacle and a sound response. Leave unsupported predictions open.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What is happening now?" Separate current evidence from a future story. A more cheerful forecast needs evidence too; reasonable precautions can proceed under uncertainty.

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